had lost our eighth wicket with 92 runs still to get and Laxman, nursing a sore back, was our only hope. He batted like a man possessed, supported by Ishant Sharma, who showed exemplary grit for his 31. Though Ishant fell with 11 runs still to get, Laxman batted on and took us over the line, to win by one wicket. Laxman tormented the Australians throughout his career and this was another occasion when they threw everything at him but still couldn't dislodge him. Laxman is one of the few batsmen capable of playing two different shots off every ball and his supple wrists made him a joy to watch from the other end.

Having beaten Australia at Mohali, we had already retained the Border-Gavaskar Trophy when we arrived at Bangalore for the second and final Test of the series on 9 October. At the Chinnaswamy Stadium, Australia batted first, scoring a healthy 478, helped by a career-best 128 from Marcus North. I felt in good form from the very start of my innings. Not out on 44 at the end of day two, I batted through the whole of the next day and remained unbeaten on 191. I reached my forty-ninth Test hundred with consecutive sixes off Nathan Hauritz. It was my sixth Test century of the year and I had amassed more than 1000 Test runs in a calendar year for the sixth time in my career.

I eventually fell for 214 and, with the help of Murali Vijay's 139, we managed a slender first-innings lead of seven runs before our bowlers got in on the act and dismissed Australia for just 223 in their second innings. We needed 207 to win the series 2–0 and I had the privilege of taking the team to victory with young Cheteshwar Pujara, who, on debut, scored a valiant 72 not out batting at number three, a position he has now made his own for India. I am convinced he has a great future ahead of him as a Test player.

An unwelcome distraction

Next up was a three-Test home series against New Zealand in November 2010. Though we won the series 1–0, my own form took a dip. Everyone had started talking about my fiftieth Test hundred and it became hard to concentrate. The crowds were trying to get behind me and in Hyderabad, during the second Test, people kept waving at me even when I was batting. My usual routine was to walk away towards the square-leg umpire after playing each ball, but the crowd at square leg went up every time I looked at them, which unsettled me. I know they meant well, but I